

A circular pit nearly fills this chamber, leaving only a foot-wide pathway between the edge of the pit and the wall. The pit is filled to about five feet below the lip with humanoid bones. A narrow walkway hugging the walls is the only path through the chamber.

Narrow niches in the walls are filled with carefully placed bones, baubles, and other similar items.

The encircling pathway is only about a foot wide. To walk the path without falling into the pit requires a successful DC 5 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check. Falling into the **jagged bones in the pit** causes 3 (1d6) points of piercing damage.

Falling into the pit and the subsequent struggle to get out makes enough noise to alert the **ghouls** who are hiding in area 5. If the adventurers end up not proceeding into area 5, their presence is known by the ghouls, who stalk them and attack them during their next fight.

5. FUNERARY CULTS

Over the centuries, a handful of exclusive funerary cults have flourished in Phlan. This section of the catacombs was reserved for their use. (The pit in area 4 was the work of one of these cults.) One room contains row upon row of pottery animals that were made from the ashes and ground bones of the deceased. Another contains thousands upon thousands of disarticulated bones hanging by thin wires from the ceiling so that no two bones touch each other.

The only important chamber here is one that smells powerfully of smoke; it contains many dozens of bodies preserved by the smoke from aromatic charcoal burned in iron braziers (now unlit). The corpses are well preserved but jet black.

The smell of wood smoke is overpowering in this room, and every surface is stained jet black with soot that must have come from the two great iron braziers on the floor. The walls are lined with almost perfectly preserved bodies—black from the same soot that stains the walls. They might almost be mistaken for mummified drow were it not for the different colors of hair.

Several corpses, however, have been ravaged by something. They lay in the center of the room, torn apart, their flesh and bones gnawed by some ravenous creature.

The preserved bodies drew two hungry **ghouls** to this area, and they're still present, hidden among the

corpses. They hid among the bodies when they heard the characters approaching (make a single Dexterity (Stealth) check with a +4 bonus). Any adventurer who's passive Wisdom (Perception) score exceeds the result of their Dexterity (Stealth) check notices the ghouls.

Upon realizing that they have been discovered, the ghouls attack. Otherwise, they attack at the most advantageous moment if no one spots them. If the adventurers do not venture further into the room, the ghouls attempt to stalk the adventurers and attack them during their next fight.

"Well, that about does it for me. You know I don't get paid for this, right?"

--Cassyt

ADJUSTING THE ENCOUNTER

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak party:** remove one ghoul
- **Weak party:** change one ghoul to a zombie
- **Strong party:** add one ghoul
- **Very strong party:** add three ghouls

6. RICKETY STAIRS

The passage descends by shallow stone steps to a 15-foot by 15-foot square room. Wooden stairs wind around the walls of the shaft down into the darkness.

The stairs look as though they are ancient, and the wood rotted and weak.

They wind around a tall statue of a strange, four-armed humanoid with vaguely insectoid features. It clutches a scroll in one hand, a quill in a second, a skull in a third, while the fourth is empty.

The floor of the room is about 20 feet below that of the hallway leading into it, and the steps are about 3 feet wide. The **stairs are also on the verge of collapse**. Each character who uses the steps must make a DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check at the midpoint of the stairs as they descend or ascend. An unsuccessful check causes 5 points of damage to the stairs. If the check succeeds, no damage is dealt to the stairs.

Describe the creaking, cracking, and groaning from the ancient wood, and the dust that falls with every step. The staircase collapses when it accumulates 10 points of damage, dropping everyone on it to the floor of the room. Any character who is on the stairs when they collapse suffers 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage and falls prone.

The noise of the collapsing stairs draws the attention of the zombies in Area 7 who come to investigate the disturbance.

On the plus side, the collapse leaves plenty of handholds and footholds where wooden posts were set into the stone, so the walls can be climbed with a successful DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check. The DC of this check is lowered to 5 if the adventurers also use a rope to climb.

Any adventurer succeeding at a DC 15 Intelligence (Religion) check identifies the statue at the bottom as that of Jergal, an ancient deity charged with recording the disposition of the souls and guarding the tombs of the dead.

“And how do you expect me to get down?!”

--Cassyt

TREASURE

The statue's eyes are two pieces of flawless jet worth 25 gp each.

Cassyt will inform Doomguide Glandon if she sees any of the adventurers take either of the gems.

PART 3. THE LOWER

CATACOMBS

The catacombs beyond this point are hundreds of years old and starting to show their age.

LOOSE BRICKWORK

The walls and ceilings of this section of the catacombs are old and in poor repair. While damaged walls or ceiling won't collapse under normal conditions, under certain circumstances, they collapse. If a character casts *thunderwave* or another ability with a similar effect, the intense vibrations trigger a collapse. Falling stonework causes 4 (1d8) bludgeoning damage to each creature in the room where the spell is cast. This damage is halved if the creature succeeds at a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw.

7A. SUN PIT

This room was used as a means of destroying vampires. Vampires were staked and shackled to the wall. When the morning sun rose, it would eventually shine down through the grates above, destroying the vampires.

This square room is approximately 20 feet across. The ceiling, far above, is capped with iron grates through which the sky above can be seen.

Shackles are bolted to the walls and an iron lockbox is fastened to the wall. The lid to the lockbox is open, revealing a number of wooden stakes.

Though it is difficult to be sure, a hinged gate in the grate above seems to be open and a length of rope ending in a grappling hook lays in a heap on the floor in front of you beside a short, rusted iron bar.

A group of four **zombies** are in this room, having been attracted by the noise made by the would-be thieves.

A couple of thieves have broken into the catacombs. When the last of them was climbing down, the bar that the grappling hook was hanging from broke loose and sent one of them falling the last 10 feet and worse yet, alerting a pack of zombies to their presence. They took refuge in Area 7b. When the adventurers arrive, the zombies are banging on the door that the Welcomers have barricaded themselves behind. They attack the adventurers should any of them enter this Area.

ADJUSTING THE ENCOUNTER

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak or weak party:** remove two zombies
- **Strong party:** two additional zombies wander into the room at the beginning of the second round
- **Very strong party:** a ghoul wanders into the room at the beginning of the second round

7B. CREMATORIA NICHES

This room is used to house people whose remains have been cremated; a practice that only recently came into fashion.

Unbeknownst to the Kelemvorites, a group of thieves have stolen into the catacombs amidst the disruption caused by the appearance of undead.

The walls of this long room bear hundreds upon hundreds of niches; most of which bear a small urn or box, and a trinket or two.

An elf, a tiefling and a hiccupping half-orc crouch on the far side of the room, clutching swords in their shaking hands.

A trio of Welcomers—a half-orc **spy**, an elf **bandit**, and a tiefling **bandit**—have taken refuge in this area.

Specifically chosen for the job because they possess darkvision, they originally snuck into the catacombs two days ago to investigate the rumors of undead, but couldn't resist pilfering some of the items in the room. By the time they realized that their activities attracted the attention of some roaming zombies, it was too late; they barred the door and have been waiting here ever since.

They planned rather poorly and between them had only a single flask of rather potent whiskey. Upon realizing that they were trapped, the half-orc spy refused to share the whiskey with the elf and the tiefling, and has been well-and-truly drunk ever since. The Welcomers are initially relieved to found by the party and beg the adventurers for whatever food or water they have. The half-orc is doubly pleased and offers everyone within reach an awkward (and rather smelly) hug.

PLUNDERED TREASURES

Any character succeeding at a DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check notices that each of the Welcomers has a few trinkets stuffed into their pockets. The adventurers can persuade the Welcomers into leaving the treasures behind with a successful DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation or Persuasion). If unsuccessful, nothing short of force is going to deter them from absconding

with the treasure.

If it comes to blows and any of the Welcomers are killed in the struggle, the adventurers receive the **Enmity of the Welcomers** (see Favors and Enmity, below).

Cassyt will inform Doomguide Glandon if she sees any of the adventurers take any of the treasure belonging to the dead.

HELPING THE WELCOMERS ESCAPE

The Welcomers want to leave the catacombs, preferably via the way they entered as they do not want the Kelemvorites knowing that they were down here. However, if faced with choosing between leaving out the front door and staying in the catacombs, they choose the former and upon leaving the catacombs are confronted by the Kelemvorites. Cassyt urges the party not to help them sneak out, but can be persuaded to turn a blind eye with a successful DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check.

If the adventurers decide to help the Welcomers sneak out, they not only need to secure a line up, but they also need to come up with a way to get the half-orc out as he is clearly in no state to make the climb. The adventurers can use the grappling hook and hook it to the grate above with a successful DC 15 Strength or Dexterity check.

Once the grappling hook is secure or the adventurers have otherwise secured a rope to the grate above, the elf and the tiefling climb out with no problem. The half-orc can't, however, and needs to be hauled up. Because they are not on the best of terms with the stingy half-orc, the elf and the tiefling are unwilling to wait for him to sober up. They will provide a limited amount of help to the adventurers to haul the half-orc up if they ask for it.

Between the three of them, they possess the following equipment:

- Three, 50 ft. lengths of hempen rope;
- Two sets of thieves' tools;
- A bag of ball bearings; and
- A nearly empty flask of rather potent whiskey.

Allow the players to get creative with how they would like to try and get the half-orc up. The easiest way would require a block and tackle. Thankfully, there is one in area 2. If the adventurers do not remember the block and tackle, any adventurer succeeding at a DC 10 Intelligence check remembers seeing the block and tackle. If the adventurers think to ask Cassyt, she thinks for a moment and then remembers that the Kelemvorites use one in area 2 to lower bodies into the

catacombs.

A character must succeed on two successive DC 15 Strength checks in order to hoist the half-orc spy up to the grate above. If they are using the block and tackle from area 2, this check is made with advantage. The elf and the tiefling refuse to help pull.

CASSYT

If the adventurers help the Welcomers sneak out, Cassyt is naturally upset. However, she is young and relatively naïve, and can be persuaded to keep mum about it with a successful DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check. Feel free to award advantage on this check for especially creative roleplaying.

"Doomguide Glandon isn't going to be pleased to hear about this..."

--Cassyt

TREASURE

The Welcomers have looted a total of 80 gp in various types of plundered trinkets and art objects. They also carry 20 gp in coins of their own.

An additional 50 gp worth of coins and trinkets can be further pilfered from the niches that the Welcomers didn't empty.

8. OBELISK

The walls of this semi-circular chamber are lined with nearly a hundred loculi, each containing the bones of one or more deceased residents of Phlan. An obelisk stands in the center of the chamber. Its four faces are covered in mysterious runes.

The carvings are in Celestial and use its intricate, flowing script. If no one in the party understands Celestial, the language can be identified only with at least a minute's study and a successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check. The writing is not terribly interesting; it speaks in general terms about the goodly lives of those interred in the chamber.

The corridor continues to the east and down a set of stairs.

9. SKELETAL CEILING

The walls in this section are lined with burial niches containing skeletons, as in other areas of the catacombs, but skeletons also stare down at you from the ceiling where they were set into shallow plaster. Some arm bones, leg bones, and skulls have cracked free and fallen to the floor, but most remain in the positions and poses they were given ages ago.

Rorreth Monforth animated five **skeletons** in the ceiling as guardians where they've remained quietly in the ceiling for more than a week. As the adventurers pass beneath them, the skeletons break free from the plaster and drop down to attack. Stage this situation for maximum drama among your players. It might be most effective, for example, to have only half the skeletons drop down on the first round. On the second and third rounds, more can drop into the fight in locations where they directly threaten characters who try to avoid melee, such as spellcasters and archers.

ADJUSTING THE ENCOUNTER

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak party:** remove three skeletons
- **Weak party:** remove two skeletons
- **Strong party:** add one skeleton; all living creatures in the room take 4 (1d8) points of slashing damage from jagged chunks of plaster when the skeletons break loose. Creatures who succeed at a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw take no damage.
- **Very strong party:** add two skeletons; all living creatures in the room take 4 (1d8) points of slashing and bludgeoning damage from jagged chunks of plaster when the skeletons break loose. Creatures who succeed at a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw take no damage.

"Gah!"

--Cassyt

10. THE TOMB OF SEDRAIR II

A mummified figure in magnificent apparel sits on a throne inlaid with ivory and semiprecious stones. It holds a golden dagger in its right hand and a balance in its left. A crown of gold and tarnished silver seems to float above its head. The whole scene is draped in cobwebs.

In life, this was Sedrair II, one of the richer (and more eccentric) grander nobles of Phlan centuries ago. Paranoid even in death, her crown is warded against theft by a clever **glyph**.

The balance is the type with two pans suspended from a lightweight beam. A secret compartment in the chair holds a box of weights; the compartment can be noticed with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check. The scales are not in balance when the adventurers arrive, due to the accumulation of dust and debris over the ages, but it really doesn't matter—rebalancing the pans with the hidden weights or anything else does nothing.

The crown is not floating above the skull but is suspended by thin wires ending in small hooks. Cobwebs camouflage the wires; they are noticed only by adventurers who succeed at a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check.

The wires are linked to the glyph, which is triggered if the weight on the wires increases or decreases by more than a few ounces. The trap is a *glyph of warding* that causes 9 (2d8) lightning damage to everyone in the chamber; a successful DC 13 Dexterity saving throw halves the damage.

Clever characters might try to neutralize the trap using the weights from the throne. This can be done, but it's tricky. With a successful DC 20 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check, the crown can be removed by replacing it with weights. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check beforehand allows the adventurer to approximate the weight of the crown; granting advantage on the Dexterity check. Failure on the Dexterity check sets off the trap.

"Not that you would listen to me anyway, I just thought you should know that Sedrair was quite fond of her gold. She probably wouldn't appreciate your mucking about with it."

--Cassyt

TREASURE

Sedrair's crown is worth 250 gp if it's recovered without setting off the trap; if the trap goes off, damage from the lightning reduces its value to just 50 gp. The fine set of weights is worth 120 gp if complete and the balance accompanies it. The weights alone are worth 80 gp if complete or 10 gp if some of the weights were left behind. The golden dagger is only plating over soft metal; it's worth 12 gp, and it's useless as a weapon. Other semiprecious stones and filigree that can be collected from the throne have a total value of 8 gp.

Cassyt will inform Doomguide Glandon if she sees any of the adventurers take any of the treasure from Sedrair's Tomb.